

Local Supplement to the Department of the Navy Correspondence Manual





DEPARTMENT OF THE NAVY
UNITED STATES NAVAL ACADEMY
121 BLAKE ROAD
ANNAPOLIS MARYLAND 21402-1300

USNAINST 5216.1R
28/Flag Sec
21 Apr 2022

USNA INSTRUCTION 5216.1R

From: Superintendent, U.S. Naval Academy

Subj: LOCAL SUPPLEMENT TO THE DEPARTMENT OF THE NAVY
CORRESPONDENCE MANUAL

Ref: (a) SECNAV M-5216.5
(b) OPNAV M-5215.1
(c) SECNAV M-5210.2
(d) Writing Style Guide and Preferred Usage for DoD Issuances

1. Purpose. Establish administration and correspondence responsibilities and procedures for the U.S. Naval Academy (USNA) to supplement procedures established in references (a) through (d).

2. Cancellation. USNAINST 5216.1Q.

3. Scope and Applicability. This instruction applies to all personnel and subordinate unit identification codes that report to the Superintendent.

4. Policy. Personnel preparing correspondence and directives should follow the guidelines contained in references (a) and (b) without exception. This instruction provides details applicable to USNA correspondence and directives.

a. Correspondence Manager. The Superintendent's Flag Secretary is designated as both the Correspondence and Directives Manager for USNA.

b. This instruction is divided into four chapters:

- (1) Chapter 1: Correspondence Policies
- (2) Chapter 2: Delegation to Sign "By Direction" and Letterhead
- (3) Chapter 3: Correspondence Formatting
- (4) Chapter 4: Standards and Style

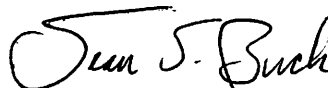
5. Records Management

a. Records created as a result of this instruction, regardless of format or media, must be maintained and dispositioned per the records disposition schedules located on the DON Assistant for Administration, Directives and Records Management Division portal page at <https://portal.secnave.navy.mil/orgs/DUSNM/DONAA/DRM/Records-and-InformationManagement/Approved%20Record%20Schedules/Forms/AllItems.aspx>.

b. For questions concerning the management of records related to this instruction or the records disposition schedules, please contact your local record custodian or the USNA Records Manager.

6. Review and Effective Date. Per OPNAVINST 5215.17A, the Flag Secretary will review this instruction annually on the anniversary of its effective date to ensure applicability, currency, and consistency with Federal, DoD, SECNAV, and Navy policy and statutory authority using OPNAV 5215/40 Review of Instruction.

7. Forms. Standard Form 901 Controlled Unclassified Information (CUI) Coversheet can be found on the GSA Forms Library website at <https://www.gsa.gov/reference/forms#>. USNA Form 5216/3 Briefing Sheet can be obtained on the USNA website, <http://intranet.usna.edu/AdminSupport/chop-sheets.php> or on the official USNA Forms List at <https://www.usna.edu/AdminSupport/FormsProgram/USNAOfficialFormsList.php>. Both forms should be used and submitted in accordance with this manual.


S. S. BUCK

Releasability and distribution:

This instruction is cleared for public release and is available electronically only via USNA's Issuance website, <https://www.usna.edu/AdminSupport/Inst/>.

TABLE OF CONTENTS

Chapter 1 CORRESPONDENCE POLICIES	1-1
1. Guidelines for Superintendent's Signature	1-1
2. Reply Timelines	1-1
3. Briefing Sheet	1-1
4. Folder Assembly	1-1
5. Delivery	1-2
6. Subordinate Review Guidelines	1-2
7. Documents for Higher Headquarters	1-3
 CHAPTER 2 DELEGATION TO SIGN "BY DIRECTION" AND LETTERHEAD	
1. Delegation to Sign "By Direction"	2-1
2. Letterhead Stationery	2-2
 CHAPTER 3 FORMATTING	
3-1	
1. General	3-1
2. Sender's Symbols	3-1
3. "From" Line	3-1
4. Signature Block	3-2
5. Originator Codes	3-2
 CHAPTER 4 STANDARDS AND STYLE	
4-1	
1. Accuracy, Brevity, and Clarity	4-1
2. Capitalization	4-2
3. Acronyms and Abbreviations	4-3
4. Punctuation	4-3
5. Numbers	4-3
6. Virgules (Slashes) and "and/or"	4-4
7. Echelon	4-4

CHAPTER 1
CORRESPONDENCE POLICIES

1. Guidelines for Superintendent's Signature. Unless specifically delegated, the Superintendent will sign all Congressional responses and any correspondence or directive that determines broad policy or is required by law or regulation.

2. Reply Promptly

a. Routine correspondence will be completed within 10 working days.

b. Congressional replies, unless otherwise specified, should be answered within 5 working days. If a reply cannot be prepared in 5 working days, USNA will send an interim reply.

3. Briefing Sheet. Every folder delivered to Larson Hall for the Superintendent or Chief of Staff will include USNA 5216/3 Briefing Sheet printed on blue paper.

a. USNA 5216/3, or "Blue Blazer," provides an executive summary and confirms that the appropriate chains of command and cost center heads have reviewed and edited the correspondence or directive.

b. Complete all required sections of USNA 5216/3. The name and phone number of the person drafting the document, not the name of the office, is required. If the correspondence is self-explanatory, type "Recommend signature" in the briefing portion. The sheet must contain the initials of reviewers through the chain(s) of command and applicable cost center head(s).

c. Indicate the numerical chop order on the "Routing Order" section. Individuals chopping shall include the date initialed in the date column.

d. Complete the "Originating Office" and "Date" portion in the lower left-hand corner.

4. Folder Assembly. Folders delivered to Larson Hall for the Superintendent or Chief of Staff will be 9"x12" pocket folders with the USNA crest centered on the front of the folder.

a. Do not include intra cost center routing sheets. Folders are color coded as follows:

(1) Blue: General correspondence

(2) Red: Personnel matters

(3) Green: Supply and financial

b. Assemble the folders as follows:

(1) On the outside, upper right hand corner of each folder, attach an Avery 5160 label and write or type the subject and originating office.

(2) Left side: Place USNA 5216/3 on top of any tabbed reference material and, if necessary, completed envelopes.

(3) Right side: Place drafted documents requiring review and signature.

c. Controlled Unclassified Information (CUI). If the folder contains CUI to include Personal Identifiable Information (PII), affix Standard Form 901 Controlled Unclassified Information Coversheet to the outside cover of the folder before routing. Complete the CUI Designation Indicator block in the first attention field. Instructions for completing a CUI Designation Indicator block are found in DoD Instruction 5200.48.

5. Delivery. For all documents delivered to Larson Hall for the Superintendent or Chief of Staff, provide a hard copy to the administrative assistant on the second deck of Larson Hall and e-mail an electronic copy to admin-routing@usna.edu.

6. Subordinate Review Guidelines

a. Before documents are forwarded to Larson Hall for the Superintendent's signature, one or more members of the Senior Leadership Team will review and indicate approval by initialing the Briefing Sheet.

b. For correspondence within their areas of responsibility, the following will also review correspondence and indicate approval by initialing the Briefing Sheet.

(1) Comptroller. All documents governing:

(a) The financial management of USNA funds for Operations and Maintenance, Navy; Other Procurement, Navy; gifts to USNA and the Museum; Research, Development, Test, and Evaluation; and reimbursable money from outside sources.

(b) Financial programming, budgeting, accounting, or allocation.

(c) Commercial activities studies.

(d) USNA manning requirements.

(e) Inter-service support agreements and memos of understanding and agreement.

(f) The travel program including the Government Travel Charge Card, Unit Travel Card, and Centrally Billed Accounts.

(g) The Government Commercial Purchase Card.

(h) USNA cost reports including Cost Per Graduate, Cost of Education, Integrated Postsecondary Education Data System, and Annual Institutional Profile.

(i) Minor and Plant Property management.

(j) Payroll, time, and attendance.

(2) Staff Judge Advocate (SJA). As the Superintendent's principal uniformed legal advisor, the SJA will review all legal documents related to military personnel including administrative and disciplinary actions and interpreting laws and regulation. As the Command Ethics Advisor, the SJA will review all documents relating to ethics and standards of conduct. The SJA and Command Counsel coordinate legal issues internally as appropriate.

(3) Command Counsel. As the Superintendent's principal civilian legal advisor, the incumbent will review all legal documents related to or impacting USNA's civilian workforce or business activities (contracts, fiscal law, etc.). The Command Counsel and SJA coordinate legal issues internally as appropriate.

(4) Personnel Officer. All documents concerning officer and enlisted personnel matters including awards, fitness reports and evaluations, endorsements, all requests for specific Navy or Marine Corps programs, retirement, resignation, augmentation, and change of designator.

(5) Public Affairs Officer. All documents involving the media or USNA personnel likely to cause public interest.

(6) Security Manager. All documents containing or pertaining to classified information or clearance matters.

(7) Senior Marine Corps Representative. All documents regarding Marine Corps matters.

7. Documents for Higher Headquarters. Documents for signature or review of any higher headquarters will be prepared per reference (a).

a. The originator will include draft copies of all required documents when routing to Larson Hall.

b. The complete package will be entered into the appropriate tasking system by the Superintendent's administrative office.

USNAINST 5216.1R
21 Apr 2022

c. Once documents have been signed by the Superintendent, the Administrative Office will e-mail a scanned copy to the originator.

CHAPTER 2
DELEGATION TO SIGN “BY DIRECTION” AND LETTERHEAD

1. **By Direction.** Certain billets are authorized to sign “By direction” for routine official naval correspondence addressed “From: Superintendent, U.S. Naval Academy,” utilizing the “United States Naval Academy” letterhead. Personnel designated to sign “By direction” are given this authority due to the position they occupy and only for correspondence germane to their position. This authorization does not apply to items relating to the mission or efficiency of the Academy that are addressed to a higher authority, involve certain aspects of military justice, establish command wide policy or censure or criticism of any kind. Personnel authorized to sign by direction are:

- a. Academic Dean and Provost (signs as Academic Dean and Provost)
- b. Administrative Officer for Privacy Act and Freedom of Information Act matters (signs as Privacy Act or Freedom of Information Act Officer)
- c. Chief Diversity Officer
- d. Chief of Staff (signs as Chief of Staff on all documents and USNA directives unless applicable regulations prohibit delegation of signatory authority. Major policy changes and strategic institutional documents should still be prepared for signature by the Superintendent).
- e. Command Chaplain
- f. Command Climate Specialist
- g. Command Counsel
- h. Command Evaluation Officer
- i. Commandant of Midshipmen (signs as Commandant of Midshipmen)
- j. Deputy Commandant of Midshipmen (signs in absence of Commandant of Midshipmen)
- k. Deputy Commandant for Leadership and Character Development
- l. Deputy Commandant for Professional Development
- m. Comptroller
- n. Dean of Admissions (signs as Dean of Admissions)
- o. Deputy for Finance (signs as Deputy for Finance)

- p. Deputy for Information Technology and Chief Information Officer
- q. *Director of Athletics
- r. Director, Government Affairs
- s. Director, Human Resources
- t. Director, Naval Academy Business Services Division
- u. Director, Research and Scholarship
- v. Director, U.S. Naval Academy Band
- w. Director, Vice Admiral James B. Stockdale Center for Ethical Leadership
- x. Enlisted Personnel Officer (signs in absence of Personnel Officer for enlisted personnel matters only)
- y. Executive Director for Strategy
- z. Personnel Officer
- aa. Public Affairs Officer
- ab. Registrar (signs as Registrar for transcripts, diplomas, and attendance/graduation verifications)
- ac. Security Manager
- ad. Sexual Assault Prevention and Response Program Manager
- ae. Staff Judge Advocate

*All USNA policy and directives pertaining to faculty, staff, or midshipmen shall be cosigned by the Military Deputy Director of Athletics.

2. Signing “By direction”. Except for the Academic Dean and Provost, Administrative Officer, Chief of Staff, Commandant of Midshipmen, Deputy for Finance, Dean of Admissions, and the Registrar, individuals authorized to sign “By direction” will not address or sign standard letters on USNA letterhead to activities or offices outside USNA using their billet title.

3. Naval Academy Letterhead Stationery

a. "United States Naval Academy" command letterhead stationery is only used for standard letters, memos, and other official business coming from the Superintendent. This is the letterhead that needs to be used when a directive/governing document requires correspondence to be on "command letterhead." Only the Superintendent and those delegated to sign "By direction" of the Superintendent, listed above, can sign on this letterhead.

b. "USNA Office of the Superintendent" letterhead stationery is only for business letters, letters of a personal nature, and letter to members of Congress. Only the Superintendent signs on this letterhead.

c. Other authorized USNA Letterhead Stationery that bears the seal of the DoD. Below are the only other authorized USNA letterhead stationery:

Office of the Commandant of Midshipmen
Office of the Provost
Director of Athletics
Office of the Dean of Admissions
Deputy for Information Technology/Chief Information Officer
Deputy for Finance
Naval Academy Business Services Division
Nimitz Library
Museum
Office of the Command Chaplain
Senior Marine Corps Representative
Chief Diversity Officer

(1) The above letterhead is used for correspondence and official business coming from the head of the department of the corresponding letterhead. Only the heads of the departments listed above are authorized to sign on their respective letterhead.

(2) The head of the department may designate personnel to sign "By direction" on their respective letterhead by memo or designation letter.

(3) If you are not a head of one of the above departments or have designated "By direction" authority, you are not authorized to sign on any version of USNA letterhead.

d. University Stationery. University stationery is stationery that bears the crest/seal of the Academy but does not bear the DoD seal. This stationery is only authorized for correspondence requiring the University seal/crest, but is not an official matter of the command or the DoD. An example of use for this stationery is academic letters of recommendation for midshipmen that are to be sent to non-DoD universities/entities. No delegation is required to sign University stationery, but it is only authorized if all the following conditions are met:

- (1) The stationery is uniform throughout the cost center,
 - (2) The stationery is designed utilizing the approved University fonts, colors, and graphics found on the Public Affairs Office website at <https://intranet.usna.edu/PAO/graphics.php>,
 - (3) The stationery is approved by the Cost Center Head, and
 - (4) The stationery is not used when Naval Academy or DoD letterhead is appropriate.
- e. Naval Academy Preprinted and Computer Generated Letterhead Stationery uses and Procurement.

(1) Preprinted Naval Academy Letterhead Stationery. Offices are not permitted to electronically generate preprinted Naval Academy letterhead stationery that bears the DoD seal. All approved Naval Academy printed letterhead stationery (authorized letterhead listed in paragraph 3c above) shall be purchased through the Defense Automated Printing Service (DAPS), Annapolis and should correspond to the specifications for preprinted letterhead stationery listed in Appendix C of SECNAV M-5216.5. Helvetica Roman is the preferred USNA preprinted letterhead stationery font.

(2) Computer Generated Naval Academy Letterhead Stationery. Computer generated Naval Academy letterhead stationery is an acceptable substitute for preprinted USNA letterhead when no signature is required or a digital signature is to be used. Digital signatures must meet the requirements of SECNAVINST 5239.24 DON Digital Signature Policy. If a hard signature is required, preprinted letterhead must be used. Computer generated USNA letterhead must conform to the computer generated letterhead stationery specifications listed in Appendix C of SECNAV M-5216.5 and are different than preprinted letterhead standards. Times New Roman is the preferred USNA computer generated letterhead stationery font.

f. Routing Documents Requiring Letterhead for Superintendent's Signature. Route all correspondence needing the Superintendent's signature on plain white bond paper to Larson Hall and send an electronic copy to admin-routing@usna.edu. After the correspondence is checked for accuracy, the Superintendent's administrative office will print the correspondence on the correct letterhead for signature.

CHAPTER 3
FORMATTING

1. General

a. Use Times New Roman font, pitch 12 (pitch 13 for action and info memos) for all correspondence and directives.

b. Margins will be 1 inch for top, bottom, left, and right on each page.

c. Left justify text.

2. Sender's Symbols. Sender's symbols have three parts and will be included on all standard naval letters, business letters, endorsements, memos, and directives signed by the Superintendent or Chief of Staff. Note, some of the Superintendent's executive correspondence will only include the date in civilian format.

a. Standard Subject Identification Code (SSIC). An SSIC is a four or five digit number categorizing a document's subject and is required on most USNA correspondence, directives, forms, and reports. Refer to reference (c) for the appropriate SSIC.

b. Originator Code. Correspondence will include an originator code preceded by "Ser" and followed by a slash and the three-digit serial number. For example, "Ser 4/010". See paragraph five for a list of USNA originator codes.

c. Date. Date a letter for the day it will be signed; if unknown, leave the date blank.

(1) Use the abbreviated date format (DD Mos YY) when corresponding with other military organizations and the civilian format (Month DD, YYYY) when corresponding with Congress, civilian agencies and businesses, and individuals.

(2) Do not use a zero preceding the numerals 1 through 9 when the day is a single digit.

d. The longest line of the sender's symbols is right justified and the other two lines are aligned to the left edge of the longest line. The sender's symbols should reflect the following.

1531
Ser 28/001
4 Feb 21

3. "From" Line. For standard letters, the "from" line should read as:

From: Superintendent, U.S. Naval Academy

4. **Signature Blocks.** Start all lines of the signature block at the center of the page—not centered on the page—beginning on the fourth line below the text.

- a. For standard letters, memos, and endorsements:

F. M. LAST

F. M. LAST
Chief of Staff

- b. For business letters:

F. M. LAST
Vice Admiral, U.S. Navy
Superintendent

F. M. LAST
Captain, U.S. Navy
Chief of Staff

- c. The signature block for individuals authorized to sign “By direction” of the Superintendent is:

F. M. LAST
By direction

d. **Signature Blocks for Routine Email Correspondence.** Email signatures should be a professional and organizational identification of the sender along with any applicable handling instructions and/or markings for the specific email's contents and attachments. Email signatures containing quotes, sayings, proverbs, mottos, etc, not associated with the sender's organization or mission are discouraged as they generally conflict with maintaining a professional tone and can draw attention away from the email's purpose.

5. **Originator Codes.** The following identify the office preparing the correspondence:

<u>Code</u>	<u>Division or Department</u>
1	Commandant of Midshipmen
2	Office of the Provost
3	Office of the Dean of Admissions
4	Deputy for Finance (Comptroller and NABSD)
5	Institutional Research
6	Information Technology and Chief Information Officer
7	Division of Professional Development
8	School of Mathematics and Science
9	School of Engineering and Weapons
10	School of Humanities and Social Sciences
11	Office of the Registrar
12	Candidate Guidance
13	Physical Education Department

- 14 International Programs Office
- 15 Diversity Office
- 16 Division of Leadership Education and Development
- 17 Office of the Command Chaplain
- 18 Naval Academy Museum
- 19 Library
- 20 Office of the Director of Athletics
- 21 Midshipman Supply Department
- 22 Safety Office
- 23 Archives
- 24 Human Resources
- 25 Naval Health Clinic, Annapolis
- 26 Command Climate and Equal Opportunity Office
- 27 Naval Academy Sailing
- 28 Superintendent's Office (Administrative Office, Personnel Office, USNA Legal
Office, Personnel Security Office, Inspector General's Office, Sexual Assault Prevention and
Response Office, and Office of the Command Master Chief)
- 29 Unassigned
- 30 Public Affairs Office
- 31 Vice Admiral James B. Stockdale Center for Ethical Leadership

CHAPTER 4
STANDARDS AND STYLE

1. Accuracy, Brevity, and Clarity

a. The strongest letter highlights the main point in one sentence at the beginning. Put requests before justifications; answers before explanations; conclusions before discussions; and summaries before details.

b. Use short paragraphs, roughly four or five sentences; long paragraphs swamp ideas. Cover one topic completely before starting another and let a topic take several paragraphs if necessary.

c. Generally, use the active voice whenever possible. Passive voice sentences often use more words, can be vague, and can lead to a tangle of prepositional phrases. In an active voice sentence, the subject performs the action; in a passive voice sentence, the subject receives the action.

(1) A verb in the passive voice uses any form of “to be” plus the past participle of a main verb: am, is, are, was, were, be, being, been. Common solutions:

(a) Put a doer before the verb:

1. Passive: The class was taught by Professor Jones.

2. Active: Professor Jones taught the class.

(b) Change the verb:

1. Passive: Letter formats are shown in the Correspondence Manual.

2. Active: Letter formats appear in the Correspondence Manual.

d. Avoid “It is” and “There is.” These words stretch sentences, delay meaning, hide responsibility, and encourage passive verbs.

e. Avoid “the –ion of” and “the –ment of.” Most words ending in “ion” and “ment” are verbs turned into nouns. Whenever the context permits, change these words to verb forms:

Instead of

For the assumption of
For the development of
For the preparation of

Use

To assume or assuming
To develop or for developing
To prepare or for preparing

For your consideration of	Consider or considering
Make a determination	Determine
Responsible for the management of	To manage
The administration of	To administer or administering
The operation of	To operate or operating
Through the implementation of	By implementing

f. Do not use the following long-winded phrases:

<u>Instead of</u>	<u>Use</u>
As a basis for	For
As a means of	To
As a result of	Because
At the present time	Presently, now
Due to the fact that	Due to, since, because
For a period of	For
For the purpose of	For, to
Going into detail about	Detailing
In accordance with	Per, by, following, or under
In order to	To
In the amount of	For
In the event of	If
In the performance of	Performed or performing
Make provisions for	Provide
No later than	By
The use of	Use or using
Until such time as	Until

2. Capitalization

a. Unless referring to an individual, “midshipman” will be lower cased. For example, Midshipman Calvin is a first class midshipman.

b. Titles, to include military titles, and positions are not capitalized unless preceded or followed by a name. The terms such as “commanding officer,” “officer in charge,” “command master chief,” will be lower-cased unless used with an official title or name (e.g., Commanding Officer, Naval Station, Annapolis). The only exceptions are titles that indicate preeminence, such as Secretary of Defense, Secretary of the Navy, Commandant of the Marine Corps, Chief of Naval Operations, or Superintendent.

c. Ranks and rates, e.g., “captain,” “commander,” “chief petty officer,” will be lower-cased unless being used with an official title or name. “Chief Petty Officer Murphy” is capitalized, however the term “chief petty officer” used alone is not.

- d. “Sailor,” “Marine,” and the “S” in “Service member” are capitalized.
- e. Do not capitalize “naval” unless part of a proper noun, such as “Naval Air Systems Command.” When referring to the U.S. Navy, “Navy” used alone is capitalized.
- f. When referring to the Federal Government, capitalize both “Federal” and “Government.” However, “U.S. Government” is preferred when referring to the Federal Government of the United States.
- g. When using “Service” to refer to the Military Services, the “S” in “Service” is capitalized.

3. Acronyms and Abbreviations

- a. Avoid excessive abbreviating. If an abbreviation appears infrequently, spell out the term every time. Do not use an acronym if it is not cited more than three times throughout the document.
- b. Unless used as a noun, “United States” is abbreviated as “U.S.” when used as an adjective. For example, the U.S. Navy is essential for defending the coasts of the United States. Note that there is no space between the letters.
- c. Note the difference in the abbreviations for the Department of Defense (DoD) and the Department of the Navy (DON).
- d. Abbreviate midshipman as “MIDN.”

4. Punctuation

- a. Two spaces always follows periods (“.”) and colons (“:”), and one space follows semicolons (“;”) commas (“,”), and right, end parentheses (“)”).
- b. Serial or Oxford comma. Although media and public affairs guidance differ, DON documents will use a comma before the coordinating conjunction in a series of three or more. For example, USNA’s mission is “to develop midshipmen morally, mentally, and physically and to imbue them with the highest ideals of duty, honor, and loyalty in order to graduate leaders who are dedicated to a career of naval service and have potential for future development in mind and character to assume the highest responsibilities of command, citizenship, and government.”

5. Numbers

a. Eliminate the “.00” when writing money amounts with no cents. For example, use “\$175” instead of “\$175.00.”

b. Use Arabic numerals (1, 2, 3) for numbers greater than nine.

c. Measurements, time, and money are not spelled out—use figures even if less than 10 (e.g., 2 feet by 1 foot 8 inches, 3 days, 5 years). However, do not begin sentences with a numeric number. In this instance, the figure must be spelled out (e.g., instead of “4 years ago, the...”, the sentence must start as “Four years ago, the...”).

d. For phone numbers, use the format (xxx) xxx-xxxx (e.g., “(123) 456-7890”).

6. Virgules (Slashes) and “and/or”. Per reference (d) and the Federal Plain Language Guidelines, do not use virgules (“/”) when they can be replaced with “and” or “or.” Further, using “and/or” is ambiguous in documents, therefore, to avoid confusion, do not use it. In the few instances where it can be truly used, write out “either A, or B, or both.”

7. Echelon. The term “echelon” for Navy echelons is not capitalized, unless at the beginning of a sentence, and echelon levels are identified with Arabic numerals (1, 2, 3), not Roman numerals (I, II, III) (e.g., “echelon 4,” not “Echelon IV”).

8. Open all letters of reply with: "Thank you for your letter of (month day, year) concerning..." Limit replies to one page if possible.